

FundJet — Product Strategy Chat

Full conversation exported as markdown for use in Claude Code or other contexts.

Overview

Product: FundJet — group travel budgeting app

Target audience: 18–26 year olds planning group trips

Core hook: "So you can just say yes" — FundJet handles the backend work so you can travel leisurely without mentally tracking every dollar

Tagline: Plan trips, split costs, stay in sync.

What FundJet Does

- Trip creation with invite links
 - Per-member budget tracking
 - Manual expense adding with group splits
 - Flight search (Expedia API)
 - Lodging search (Booking.com API)
 - AI bank statement matching — automatically reconciles paid expenses so members don't have to check them off manually
 - Email forwarding parser (proposed) — forward any booking confirmation to a trip-specific email address, AI extracts and logs the expense automatically
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MVP Feature List

Ship now (v1)

- Trip creation + invite link
- Per-member budget + live remaining balance
- Manual expense add with group splits
- Flight search + add to trip
- Lodging search + add to trip

- **Email forwarding parser** — each trip gets a unique email (e.g. tokyo25-x7k@trips.fundjet.com), user forwards any booking confirmation, AI reads it and creates the expense automatically
- Push notifications when someone adds an expense

Save for v2

- Debt settlement ("Marcus owes Jamie \$47")
- Receipt photo scanning
- AI expense discovery for forgotten charges ("you haven't logged anything in 2 days — did you spend anything?")
- Per-category budget limits
- Trip map view
- Shared wishlist of activities

Don't build (skip for now)

- Live bank connection via Plaid — too expensive, too much friction for signup
- Full itinerary builder — Wanderlog already owns this
- Currency conversion — add only if international usage emerges

Target Audience

Primary: 18–26 year olds

Group size: 3–6 people

Who they are: College friends, post-grad groups, young couples on their first real trips. They plan in group chats, have never used a spreadsheet for a trip, and will not open a separate banking app to reconcile expenses. Budget-conscious but not broke — spending \$600–\$2,000 per trip.

What they hate:

- Chasing people for money
- Losing track mid-trip
- The awkward "who paid for what" conversation at the end
- Opening five apps to plan one trip

Who FundJet is NOT for: Families (use credit card portals), business travelers (Expensify owns them), backpackers on shoestrings

Competitive Landscape

App	Group	Booking	Budget	Auto sync
Splitwise	✓	✗	✗	✗
Tricount	✓	✗	✗	✗
Wanderlog	✓	✗	✗	✗
TravelSpend	✗	✗	✓	✗
FundJet	✓	✓	✓	✓

Nobody owns the intersection of group planning + group budgeting + booking in one place for this demographic. That's FundJet's lane.

Differentiation Strategy

Group-first by default. Every feature is designed around the fact that multiple people are involved — not as an afterthought, as the foundation.

- Flight search shows dates that work for everyone
- Hotel search filters by "fits your group, splits to X per person"
- Budget is live — everyone sees the same number in real time
- Expenses notify the group, not just the payer
- Email parser means one person forwards a confirmation and everyone's trip updates

Positioning: Don't pitch FundJet as "Splitwise but better." Pitch it as "plan and budget your trip in one place." Splitwise is for *after* the trip. FundJet is for *during* the trip. Different moment, different job.

Don't compete with Splitwise — go around them.

Target TikTok travel communities, campus travel groups, "girls trip" / "boys trip" planning content. Splitwise has zero presence there.

The Email Forwarding Parser — How It Works

1. Each trip gets a unique email address shown on the trip page
2. User books anything, anywhere (Expedia, Booking.com, Airbnb, airline sites — doesn't matter)
3. User forwards the confirmation email — one tap, 3 seconds
4. AI extracts merchant name, amount, currency, date
5. Expense appears on the trip, group gets notified, budget updates

Implementation: Postmark or SendGrid inbound email (~\$10/month) + Claude API for parsing. Booking confirmations are templated so accuracy is high immediately. Show a "review before adding" screen for first few emails to build user trust.

Total cost: Under \$50/month at early scale.

AI Bank Sync — Clarification

The AI bank matching is NOT a replacement for manual expense entry. It's a **passive confirmation and discovery layer**.

Two types of expenses:

- **Pre-planned known expenses** (flights, hotels) — AI confirms these, saves the manual check-off
- **Spontaneous forgotten expenses** (round of drinks someone else paid, split taxi at 1am) — AI *discovers* these from bank statements and flags them: "We see a \$47 charge at a Tokyo restaurant on June 14th that isn't on the trip yet — was this a group expense?"

The AI's most valuable job is the second one — surfacing forgotten charges, not rubber-stamping things people already know they paid.

Why It Hasn't Been Done Yet

It has been attempted — just not survived. Key reasons:

1. **The aggregation problem** — building three products (planning, budgeting, booking) and making them feel seamless is extremely hard. Most teams ran out of money before the UX became coherent.
2. **Cold start problem** — group apps need multiple people to sign up simultaneously. Notoriously hard acquisition problem.
3. **Booking API gatekeeping** — Expedia and Booking.com affiliate programs are hard to access at startup scale.
4. **Demographic mismatch** — most fintech founders are 30+ and build for themselves. The insight that 18–26 year olds want leisure not ledgers is surprisingly rare.

Conclusion: It's been thought of, but it's an idea that requires execution quality most teams don't reach before running out of runway. The demand is real and the gap exists for a reason you can solve.

Barrier Breakdown

1. Expedia / Booking.com API Keys

- **Difficulty:** Hard (medium-term risk)
- **Cost:** \$0 now, \$0–500/month at scale
- **Fix:** Short term — throttle and cache calls. Medium term — apply to affiliate programs properly. Nuclear option — switch to Amadeus (free developer tier) for flights, RateHawk or Hotelbeds for hotels.

2. Cold Start / Group Signup Problem EXISTENTIAL RISK

- **Difficulty:** Hardest problem on the list
- **Cost:** \$0 — purely a design problem
- **Fix:**
 - Make the invite link do real work — show trip name, destination, friend's name on the landing page
 - Allow guests — let someone add expenses without creating an account first
 - Find one super-user per friend group — market to the trip organiser, they pull everyone else in
 - Seed manually — find 5 real friend groups, sit with them, watch where it breaks

3. Email Parsing Infrastructure

- **Difficulty:** Medium (buildable in a week)
- **Cost:** \$10–50/month
- **Fix:** Postmark/SendGrid inbound webhooks + Claude API. Simple, cheap, reliable.

4. Splitwise Network Effect

- **Difficulty:** Medium
- **Cost:** \$0
- **Fix:** Don't compete — go around. Own the trip creation moment. Target TikTok travel communities where Splitwise has zero presence.

5. Running Costs at Scale

- **Difficulty:** Easy now, manageable later
- **Cost:** \$0 → ~\$2,000/month at 10,000 users
- **Revenue model:** Affiliate commissions from Expedia/Booking.com (3–8% per booking). A \$1,200 hotel booking = \$36–96 per transaction. This alone could make the product profitable without charging users.

Cost Estimates

Stage	Monthly Cost
0–1,000 users	~\$60–100/month
1,000–10,000 users	~\$500–2,000/month
Revenue unlock	Affiliate commissions at any meaningful booking volume

Market Research — Questions to Ask

Talk to people who've done a group trip in the last 12 months.

On planning pain:

- Walk me through how you planned your last group trip. What apps did you use? What happened in the group chat?
- Who ended up doing most of the organising? How did that feel?
- What was the most stressful moment of planning?

On money:

- How did you handle splitting costs? Did anyone feel they were owed money at the end?
- Did you ever feel anxious about how much you were spending mid-trip?
- Did you ever *not* do something because you weren't sure you could afford it?

On behaviour:

- Would you have paid for an app that handled this? What would make you trust it?
- What would make you get your whole friend group to sign up for something?

The last question is the most important. Its answer is your entire go-to-market strategy.

One-Sentence Brand Identity

"Every other app makes the group do the work. FundJet does the work so the group can just travel."

For Claude Code

When starting a Claude Code session, paste this file and say:

"Read PRODUCT.md first. This is the full product context for FundJet before we start building. Confirm you understand the vision, target audience, and feature priorities."

Save this file as **PRODUCT.md** in your repo root so context travels with the codebase across all sessions.

Exported from Claude.ai strategy session — FundJet product planning